



Let it slide

Nokia recently announced the 6600i Slide, it is the smallest slider phone that comes with a 5.0-megapixel camera



All talk

Nokia has unveiled a new member of its E-Series family, the Nokia E52. Topping the list of this phone's features is the eight hours of talk time that it offers

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In February this year we took a look at the entry-level cellphones available in the market. Smartphone enthusiasts were placated with promises of better things to come. It's June, our anniversary issue, and time we delivered. Smartphones are perennially a hot category, unlike digital cameras or camcorders that people tend to buy during vacations or just before festivals. Our markets are a godsend for such handsets. Cellphone prices are lower in India than in most parts of the world, and barring a few exceptions, the most popular handsets can be purchased off the street, unlocked, and ready to use with any SIM card.

Buying a simple cellphone is usually a matter of liking the way a handset looks;

being able to afford it; finding one at your nearest vendor — not necessarily in that order. The same does not apply to smartphones. Features are the name of the game here and you need to make an informed decision. Smartphones are usually created with an identity of their own and it's these slight biases that create individuality. Usage patterns determine the characteristics of a handset. For example: a smartphone with a good video player capable of playing multiple video formats will need a large, crisp screen capable of good colours; else the effort that went into designing the video component is lost. It will also need a fast processor to avoid lag and a healthy amount of integrated memory so that one can store the videos. Today's smartphones are even more converged and just when we thought manufacturers could not possibly pack any more

features on-board, we're seeing handsets with a slew of new offerings, in addition to refreshes in the technology that their predecessors sported.

Obviously such an extensive feature-set comes at a price, but we're pleased to report that on the whole it seems prices have fallen. So a new top-of-the-line smartphone will be priced at less than its predecessor, while the older model may still be available at 75 percent of its price. One of the annoyances of having a powerful multimedia device is the drain on the battery. A large screen, a backlit QWERTY keypad, a camera with integrated flash all combine to drain the battery faster than you can say "smartphone". The need for higher mAh rated batteries has not been ignored. On the average, today's smartphone comes with a healthy 1100 mAh battery; noteworthy when

you consider many notebooks come with batteries rated at the 5000 mAh mark. We're also seeing faster hardware in the form of better processors, more memory and faster flash storage. Another perpetual complaint has been the size and quality of smartphone display. Just because an executive buys a Blackberry for its seamless push-mail functionality and the attached corporate image, it doesn't mean he should have to put up with a small screen that offers horrible colours. Or a VGA camera that's as useful as a sun lamp in the Sahara desert.

This time round, we were glad to see nearly all the smartphones available with great displays in the region of 2.2-inches or more, with high-resolution screens (240 x 320 pixels at least). Many of these displays support 16 million colours bringing them closer to their desktop counterparts.

Work Hard, Play Harder...

Cell phones today are expected to serve you equally at work or at play. We test 35 multimedia and business phones, to help you decide which one suits you best